

HOW THE HAZE BUILDS
From left, heavy traffic on a smog-choked New Delhi road, Nov. 27; paddy stubble burning in Punjab, Sept. 29; a dust-laden redevelopment site in South West Delhi

ANI



PTI

moving vehicles and automatically issue fines, making manual inspections obsolete. The government must also come good on its EV promises. CM Rekha Gupta has already announced that a new policy is being developed to ensure that 100 per cent of public transport vehicles are electric by 2026. The Centre for Science and Environment, among other experts, also recommends integrated metro and bus services, with unified fares across modes and better last-mile links.

Industrial Smokescreen

On paper, Delhi seems to have achieved a green miracle: nearly all of its 1,600 registered factories now use clean piped natural gas. However, this conceals a huge shadow economy. An estimated 51,837 illegal industrial units—many in basement and back alleys of 'non-conforming' areas—continue to operate with impunity, as revealed by the records of Delhi State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation. From the dyeing units of Shiv Vihar and Seelampur to the e-waste warehouse in Mundka and Bawana's factories, these units both brazenly use diesel generators and burn waste.

Enforcement has been token. Despite setting up a 12-member special task force in 2024, only 276 units were sealed from May till June 2025. "For every unit that switched to PNG, two unauthorised ones are burning waste," says C.K. Mishra, former Union environment secretary during whose tenure the country adopted NCAP (National Clean Air Programme). "When they're under the radar, enforcers can claim they don't exist." He recalls asking states to submit pollution plans to access central funds. "What they sent were lists of machines to buy—no tough calls like shutting illegal industries. Most plans were copy-paste of each other," Mishra says.

To curb the shadow economy, say experts, enforcement should shift from physical raids to continuous digital monitoring—using tools like LIDAR drones—to detect illegal industries. Alongside this, the state should offer a one-time regularisation amnesty to help such units relocate to PNG-connected zones.

INDUSTRY

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SOLUTION
OFFER A ONE-TIME REGULARISATION AMNESTY TO HELP SUCH UNITS RELOCATE TO PNG-CONNECTED ZONES

Dust to Dust

Construction and dust contribute 35-40 per cent to Delhi's PM10 levels, the biggest source of coarse pollution. As the NCR expands rapidly, with expressways, metro lines and housing towers, the dust never settles. Unlike the greenfield cities of Noida or Gurugram, Delhi's growth is built upon brownfield demolition and reconstruction, generating more waste per square foot. NBCC's